Atlanta's Public Transit: A Proposal for Equitable Access

Summary

Atlanta has a real transportation problem and is definitely one of the P0 issues that the city faces right now. For a metro area of nearly 6 million, MARTA only covers 10% of the commuting share. Since the low-income individuals are the ones mainly using the MARTA, it hits the hardest on them considering that individuals on the west and south sides of the city (where people are generally poorer) have worse transit than their counterparts in wealthier northern neighborhoods. This was also not by coincidence.

In this proposal we are looking into why this problem exists, what happens if nothing changes, and what can be realistically done or has been already enacted about this.The main points in this article we will talk about are expanding advocacy work, which is already being done by Propel ATL, and scaling up “Marta Reach” which tackles the “last-mile” problem (which we will get into later on) for people who live far from transit stops. MARTA officially launched Reach in this month (March 2026) and there is definitely an opportunity right now to push for its expansion into the neighborhoods where it matters most.

Introduction

The Problem

Anecdotally, from talking with friends, and having done internships in the city without a car, we know that the MARTA comes with serious issues. Trains come in late compared to what they were supposed to be scheduled on Google maps, buses get randomly cancelled or even come 20 minutes late, and certain areas aren’t even connected which constitutes that “last-mile problem”. These are not random omissions since a GSU study that looked back at this data found that areas with higher poverty rates, and higher black populations, had measurably lower access to public transit even after accounting for density. When MARTA was initially built, the routes were placed so that it favoured wealthier (predominantly white) neighborhoods. Gwinnett county literally voted down MARTA expansion for decades, and based on research, though by law there was nothing racist about it, in practice, it was related to racial discrimination.

This discrepancy comes with a huge income gap. We have data from the Atlanta Regional Commission that shows median household income near Buckhead Station (the northern, more affluent parts where its predominantly white” is roughly $104,000 while West End Station, the south west area, is around $19,000. Just a few stops away. And we know that the Green Line is not as developed as the other areas.

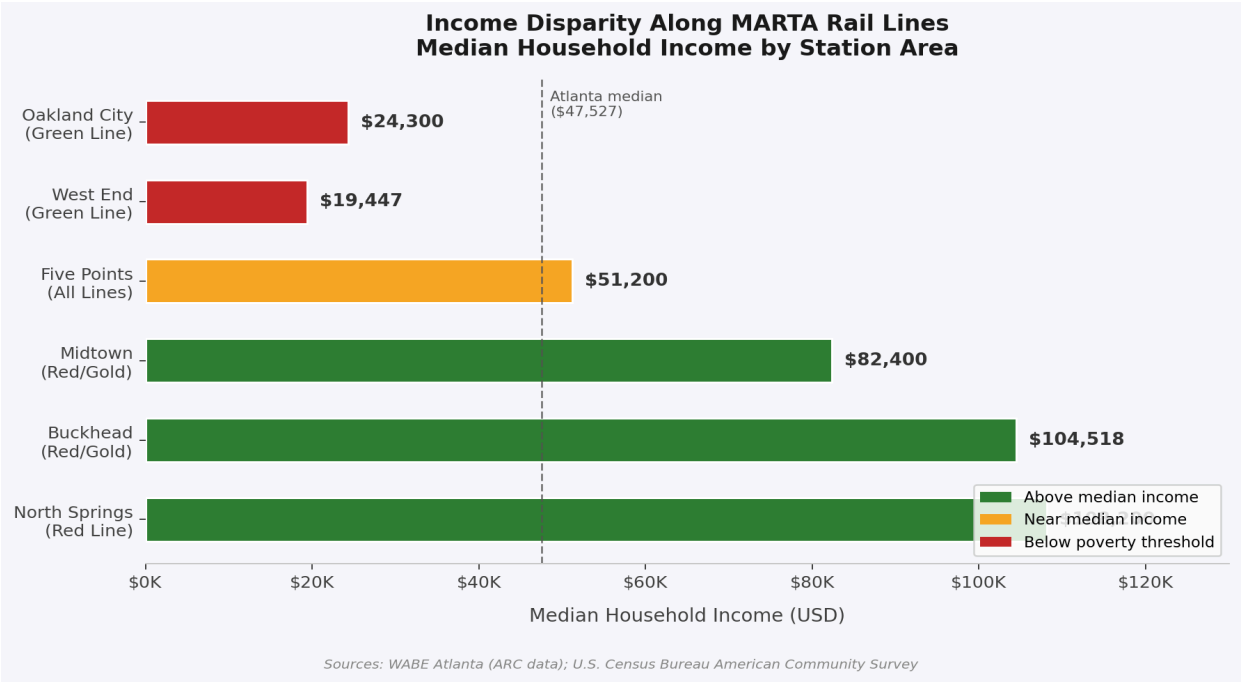

Figure 1. Median household income by MARTA station area. Sources: Atlanta Regional Commission (ARC); U.S. Census Bureau ACS.

This graph was built by Python using Matplotlib

Why This Matters at Georgia Tech

Georgia Tech is huge in the Atlanta culture, and it comes with responsibility. We have a lab, Social Aware Mobility Lab, here at GT. They already partner with MARTA Reach. We as universities have research capacity and community relationships to thread the needle on this and we have reasonable arguments that we should be still doing more of this.

What Happens If Nothing Changes

A few things come to mind by just pure analysis:

- Job access shrinks for people without cars. A major trend in urban planning over the last thirty years is that employment has suburbanized — companies have relocated headquarters, warehouses, and distribution centers to outer-ring areas that are difficult or impossible to reach by transit. Workers who remain in the city, often because they cannot afford to move, are increasingly cut off from where the jobs actually are. MARTA does not cover south and west areas where residents could connect to employers like State Farm, Mercedes-Benz, and a growing number of industrial logistics hubs.

- Job access is worsened for people without cars. This can widen the gap in income disparity and clearly relates with the specific areas that are majority Black. Companies have relocated warehouses too that are outside in outer-ring areas which make it hard to travel to.
- Atlanta is already one of the most congested cities in the country. So this doesn't only impact poor people that can't afford cars, this will increase demands in cars, causing worse traffic and just overall bad for the climate.
- Gentrification. More big tech companies like Tesla are coming into the city, and pushing lower-income residents farther.

Proposals

Recommendation 1: Support Propel ATL

Propel ATL is already an established organization that has advocated for more equitable transport. With an impressive track record they pushed a $120 million city bond so repaving projects for example would require pedestrians and bike safety improvements, among other things.

The specific recommendation is to support expanding their Walk ATL and Community Advocates Network programs into more underserved neighborhoods. These programs focus on corridors where serious crashes and deaths are most concentrated, which happen to overlap heavily with predominantly Black and low-income areas. Getting more residents in those communities organized and engaged in planning processes like the Beltline Transit Study is one of the most direct ways to ensure that future infrastructure investments actually reach the people who need them most.

Georgia Tech should contribute through volunteering, sharing this around with clubs, and create research partnerships with the relevant schools.

Recommendation 2: Scale MARTA Reach to More Neighborhoods

We see this with the Stingerette where it solves this problem within the Georgia Tech campus. The bus line takes me to specific areas, but if I want to go back to my off-campus apartment which is not necessarily covered by the bus lines, I can just use the stingerette App. Marta Reach is the same logic applied to the public transit system city-wide. We know that this works on campus, why can't we do the same in public transit?

There was a pilot program for Marta Reach, developed in partnership with Georgia Tech's ISyE department under Professor Pascal Van Hentenryck, ran from March through August 2022 in three zones: West Atlanta, Belvedere Park, and Fort Gillem. The results were meaningful. Over 7,500 trips were completed, serving more than 8,300

customers. Riders waited an average of just over seven minutes for a van after requesting one, and trips to the nearest station averaged about nine minutes. Critically, the majority of those trips were multimodal, connecting directly to rail, which means Reach was actually extending the rail network's reach rather than replacing it.

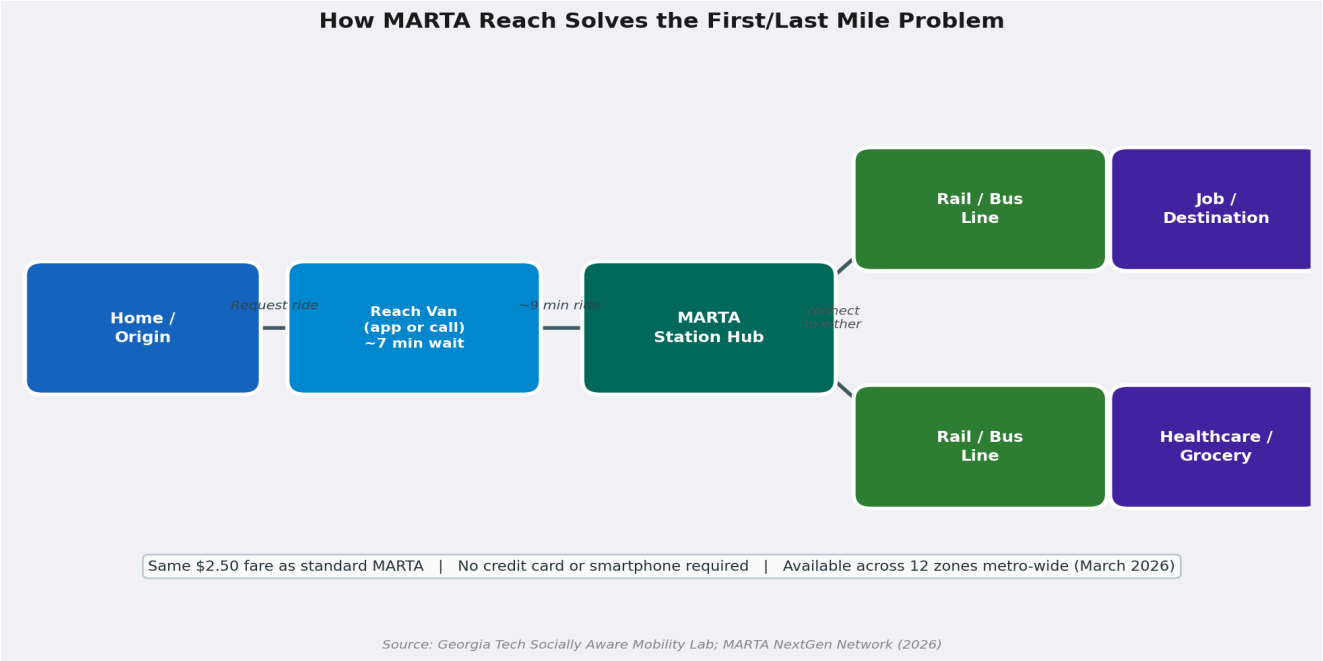

Figure 2. How MARTA Reach works: on-demand vans connect riders from their origin to a transit hub, which then links to rail or bus lines for the core of the journey. This model addresses the first/last mile gap that fixed-route systems cannot solve. Source: Georgia Tech Socially Aware Mobility Lab; MARTA (2026).

The pilot data also showed something that matters for equity, which aligns with what I was mentioning before and that the most frequent users were Black women between 25 and 34 years old. MARTA officially relaunched Reach recently as part of its NextGen Bus Network rollout, expanding from three pilot zones to twelve across the metro area. The current service includes West Atlanta, Kirkwood/Candler Park, East Point, Lakewood, Fulton Industrial, and Belvedere Park, with curb-to-curb pickup available within 30 minutes of a request.

What still needs to happen is pushing that footprint further into the neighborhoods the GSU research identified as having the worst transit access, particularly in the southwest corridor. The original pilot was also designed to work around real barriers that programs like Uber simply do not account for: no smartphone, no credit card, and no English. Riders could call a reservation line at 404-848-6622. That intentional, inclusive design is a significant differentiator, and it needs to be preserved as the program scales.

A Note on Funding and Implementation

The pilot program was funded in part by a $1 million grant from the U.S. National Science Foundation, part of the federal Mobility on Demand Sandbox Program. MARTA's broader operations are funded through a 1% sales tax in Fulton, DeKalb, and Clayton counties and a 1.5% tax in the City of Atlanta. The 2026 expansion of Reach is rolling out alongside the NextGen Bus Network, which is already funded and in motion. Extending Reach into additional underserved zones would require incremental federal grant applications or reallocation from the More MARTA capital fund, which has raised nearly $493 million since 2017. The infrastructure exists. The ask is political will and targeted grant pursuit.

Visual Descriptions for Final Draft

Visual 1: Income Disparity Along MARTA Rail Lines (Bar Chart)

The first visual is a horizontal bar chart comparing median household income across six MARTA station areas, arranged from north to south along the rail network. The data, drawn from the Atlanta Regional Commission and the U.S. Census Bureau's American Community Survey, illustrates in concrete terms what the GSU research describes statistically: wealthier neighborhoods cluster at the northern end of the system, while the poorest communities sit at the southern and western stations that were historically underserved. A dashed vertical line marks Atlanta's overall median household income of $47,527, making it immediately clear how many station areas fall below that threshold. The chart strengthens this proposal by giving readers a spatial and economic picture of the inequity, rather than asking them to take the claim on faith. Seeing that the median income near Buckhead Station is more than five times that of West End Station makes the policy argument difficult to dismiss.

Visual 2: How MARTA Reach Works (Process Diagram)

The second visual is a flow diagram showing how the MARTA Reach model addresses the first/last mile gap. It traces a rider's journey from origin to destination: a phone or call-based request, followed by an on-demand van with a roughly seven-minute wait, connecting to a MARTA station hub, which then links to rail or bus service for the core of the trip, and finally to the job, medical appointment, or grocery destination. Key facts are anchored at the bottom of the diagram: same $2.50 fare as standard MARTA, no smartphone or credit card required, and availability across twelve zones as of 2026. This visual is important because the concept of a multimodal on-demand transit system can sound abstract without a clear picture. Showing the flow step by step helps the audience understand why this is genuinely different from something like Uber, and why the integration with fixed-route transit is what makes it scalable and affordable.

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